

ARUN KUMAR

KOVAI SATHYAN
National Spokesperson, AIADMK

TN has swing door policy in elections. The DMK has never won a back-to-back election since M. Karunanidhi took over

THAMIZHACHI THANGAPANDIAN
MP, Lok Sabha (DMK)

There is no anti-incumbency in TN. We are going to polls with the confidence of winning over 200 seats

KARTI CHIDAMBARAM
MP, Lok Sabha (Congress)

CM Stalin's image is very good and he has put together a very large political formation. We will win comfortably

TAMILISAI SOUNDARARAJAN
Senior BJP leader; former Governor, Telangana

It has become fashionable to invoke BJP-ruled states whenever crime is discussed. Let's look at what's happening to women in TN



BATTLE FOR TAMIL NADU: Who Wins 2026?

SOUTHERN SHOWDOWN

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Despite some friction, the DMK-Congress relationship continues to thrive**
- **AIADMK's experiment with dual leadership cost it dear in 2021. Now, it is confident that Edappadi K. Palaniswami will be crowned as CM**
- **Vijay will not have electoral success but will be a damager**

As Tamil Nadu heads into election in April, rival alliances—Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK)-Congress and All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)-Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—sparred early at the India Today conclave.

The DMK's Thamizhachi Thangapandian and the Congress's Karti Chidambaram expressed confidence in their Secular Progressive Alliance—the INDIA bloc arm—winning the polls to the 234-member assembly, banking on what they say is chief minister M.K. Stalin's positive, consensus-builder image and the government's good performance.

The BJP's Tamilisai Soundararajan and the AIADMK's Kovai Sathyan contested the claim, charging that Stalin's "miserable rule has pushed the state into darkness, as women's safety, law and order remain in a shambles".

The two opposing sides were, however, unanimous on the damage actor Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) could do to their vote banks, even as they claim that the greenhorn might not gain much seat-wise. "Vijay is mostly noise without action, but he will eat into the votes of every party, as he is a popular star," said Sathyan. Agreed Karti: "Vijay has a fair fan following, which perhaps converts into a vote base, but seat conversion is going to be complicated. He will, however, hurt both formations."

The debate, for a large part, focused on crimes against women and girls and the alleged easy availability of drugs, with Sathyan claiming that Tamil Nadu has long surpassed Punjab to become "the drug state of India".

The question of anti-incumbency soon took centre stage. While Thamizhachi claimed no anti-incumbency at all against Stalin, Tamilisai said the NDA will win on the anti-incumbency plank. The former state BJP chief raised the topic of DMK's unfulfilled promises, including one to bring down the number of liquor shops and rampant corruption.

As April nears, the on-stage contest will now be settled at the polls. ■